

University of Bergamo

CoARA Action Plan

January 2025

1 - Introduction

On July 20, 2022, the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment was published. This policy document defines a common direction for reforming research assessment practices. It emerged from an open consultation led by the European Commission, involving various stakeholders, and was refined through a drafting process that included input from approximately 350 organizations in different roles.

The Agreement focuses on research assessment of (i) researchers, (ii) projects and (iii) research organizations. The underlying rationale is that assessments should recognize the diversity and plurality of research outputs, practices and activities that support high-quality research and maximize its impact. To this end, the Agreement delineates four main principles/commitments, along with six additional "supporting" commitments.

In 2023, the University of Bergamo (UniBg) signed the agreement formalizing its support for the principles. Subsequently, UniBg joined the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA), which comprises 716 member organizations from across the globe as of 10 January 2025. Moreover, UniBg was among the 45 Italian institutions whose initiative led to the establishment of the Italian National Chapter in September 2023, which currently has 52 member institutions.

2 - The plan

Under the **Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment**, each signatory CoARA member organization is invited to elaborate and publicly share an Action Plan, delineating the actions that it will undertake over the following five years with the objective of implementing the "core commitments".

In response to this requirement, UniBg has undertaken a comprehensive review of its own research assessment criteria, tools, and procedures. This analytical and reflective process has resulted in the formulation of an initial version of the Action Plan.

This version delineates the specific actions that UniBg is committed to implementing in the coming years. These actions are based on an in-depth analysis of the current state of research at UniBg and have been developed with meticulous consideration of the challenges and constraints posed by the national context.

UniBg is committed to conducting regular monitoring of the implementation of its Action Plan and making revisions as necessary, based on the results and reflections that emerge from the ongoing monitoring activities.

3 - The process

The formulation of the Action Plan encompassed a series of informational meetings with various internal stakeholders. These meetings had two objectives: to disseminate the vision, principles, and commitments of the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment and to understand the availability of researchers and administrative and technical staff to participate in CoARA initiatives. Moreover, the meeting provided a forum for the collection of suggestions and feedback regarding the Action Plan. The aforementioned process culminated in the drafting of the Action Plan, which has seen the active involvement of the following key actors:

- the Pro-Rectorate for Research (Deputy Rector for Research and Rector's delegate for Research Evaluation and University Ranking);
- the Directors of Departments;
- the Research Delegates of Departments;
- the Quality Assurance Unit (PQA);
- the Office of Bibliometrics, Ranking, and Open Science.

4 - The actions

The table shows the state of research evaluation at UniBg and the actions planned to align with the core commitments of CoARA.

	Commitment in the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment	State of the art at UniBg	Actions	Timeline
1.	<i>Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research</i>	<u>Salary incremental procedure</u> The recently modified system of regulation for awarding two-year economic progressions defines an evaluation scheme that takes into account both research products (in line with the system used at the university level to distribute research funds) and public engagement activities. <u>Internal research fund allocation</u> UniBg uses two centralized models for allocating to the different departments (i) internal research funds and (ii) staffing points. These models are based on an internal research assessment (IRA) carried annually. This already aligns, at least to some extent, with CoARA principles because it considers more than just scientific publications. More specifically, it is generated an overall score based on different types of "research output", namely publications, external research funds obtained, patents, and third-party activities.	Further expansion of the range of outcomes being considered in the internal process of research evaluation by including a measure of third mission activities, yet to be designed and constructed. Interest in considering ways to promote and include in the research assessment (i) open access, (ii) peer review activities, (iii) supervision/mentorship activities (of graduate/PhD students/assistants), and (iv) any other activities that emerge from the discussion. In this sense, UniBg will monitor the activities of individual CoARA working groups (e.g. the one on rewarding peer review) and of the Italian National Chapter. Each department, in its turn, establishes its own models for allocating resources to researchers. UniBg objective in this regard is to conduct a preliminary investigation with the aim of encouraging, if feasible, the alignment of these models with the central model and the principles set forth by CoARA. This process will be conducted in a manner that respects the autonomy of each department and the disciplinary specificities that characterize them.	Q2 2027 Continuous over the 5-year period Q3 2025
2.	<i>Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators</i>	<u>Other distributed resources</u> There are additional resources distributed to departments/faculty members by the university through internal calls, such as research fellowships and funding for visiting periods (incoming and outgoing). These types of resources are allocated on the basis of an evaluation that is mainly qualitative and	UniBg plans to maintain its current approach, which relies on peer review by evaluation committees and is guided by established criteria that are made public in advance.	Continuous over the 5-year period

		related to the content of the specific research project submitted by the applicants. <u>Limitations of qualitative evaluation</u> Regarding the qualitative aspect of evaluation, it seems rather difficult to imagine using peer review in the context of IRA. Indeed, this assessment takes place annually and encompasses the evaluation of a large amount of research outputs. Therefore, the implementation of a peer review process would be impractical, necessitating the pro bono involvement of a considerable number of external reviewers.		
3.	<i>Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index (as proxies for quality and impact)</i>	Indices such as the JIF and the h-index are not currently used in the IRA. In fact, apart from the potential limitations of such indicators, the central research assessment needs to be applicable to very different disciplinary fields, where certain indices may not be of primary importance. However, publications are classified according to the type of product (journal article, book chapter, monograph, etc.) and within certain types there are subcategories characterized by different scores, such as Class A (ASN) and/or indexed (Scopus/WOS) journals.	Promote discussion on the adoption of guidelines for hiring committees to consider the extent to which they should adopt practices that emphasize the importance of valuing diversity in research contributions.	Q3 2026
4.	<i>Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment</i>	UniBg adopts a critical stance towards rankings. Rankings are not used in research(er) assessment.	<i>No further action is expected</i>	
5.	<i>Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to</i>	UniBg is member of the Italian National Chapter.	Creation of an ad hoc group responsible for implementing, monitoring, and updating the actions of the plan, also in response to the outputs of the WG and the changing context. The group will also be responsible of raising awareness of research assessment reform.	Q2 2025
6.	<i>Review and develop research assessment</i>	Department Research representatives and Heads of Departments are continuously involved in the development and	Start a debate on the opportunity of including a broader range of activities and outputs into the assessment procedure for the distribution of funds to and within departments, as well	Q4 2025

	<i>criteria, tools and processes</i>	implementation of evaluation policies and practices.	as for recruitment (e.g., (i) open access, (ii) peer review activities, and (iii) supervision/mentorship activities (of graduate students/assistants).	
7.	<i>Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use</i>		Organization of ad hoc courses, designed for a variety of audiences, with a particular focus on Early-Career Researchers, to raise awareness of the principles of fair and equitable peer review and the responsible use of quantitative indicators. Raise awareness of the University's research evaluation criteria and practices among members of the research community through the intranet and research newsletter, by organising dedicated meetings and by producing easily accessible materials.	Continuous over the 5-year period Continuous over the 5-year period
8.	<i>Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition</i>		Share knowledge and practices within the National Chapter by participating in the organized meetings and initiatives.	Continuous over the 5-year period
9.	<i>Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments</i>	All documents pertaining to the local research assessment process are accessible to members of the academic community.	Publishing the CoARA roadmap on public platforms. Monitoring the roadmap implementation and report periodically to the University Governing body. Creation of a webpage dedicated to CoARA, through which regularly inform the research community at Unibg about the Action Plan and its implementation and updates.	Q1 2025 Continuous over the 5-year period Q4 2025
10.	<i>Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research</i>		It is expected that the evaluation processes will be subject to continuous monitoring, with periodic re-evaluation. This process will involve the following actors: the Deputy Rector for Research and the Rector's Delegate for Research Evaluation, the University Commission for Open Access to Scientific Literature, the PQA, the research delegates at the departments and the Bibliometric Ranking and Open Science Office.	Continuous over the 5-year period